



Desire to free Cuba sent men into peril

Relatives say they were poorly trained activists trying to send a message

BY CHRISTINE ARMARIO, SAMANTHA SCHMIDT AND AARON SCHAFFER

MIAMI — A day before Amijail Sánchez González entered Cuban waters on a Florida-registered speedboat, his family says, he called his elderly parents on the island to tell them he was heading their way.

In an hour-long phone call, they urged their son not to make the trip, his brother told The Washington Post on Thursday.

Sánchez González, a 47-year-old tree trimmer in Miami who has been critical of Cuba's communist government on social media, was wanted by Havana on accusations of promoting terrorism. In late 2024, his brother said, authorities detained their parents, both of whom are fighting cancer, and held them for months to pressure him to return to the island and turn himself in.

But he had become obsessed with his mission to “liberate Cuba,” Edisbel Sánchez González said. He wanted to show the world “an act of courage.”

Amijail Sánchez González is now under arrest in Cuba, where authorities say he and nine other Cuban nationals tried to infiltrate the country Wednesday on a speedboat “for terrorist purposes.”

According to Cuba's Interior Ministry, the men opened fired on a patrol vessel off the island's northern shore early Wednesday, wounding its commander, and the border vessel returned fire, killing four men and wounding six.

At least one of the dead crew members and one of the survivors were U.S. citizens, a U.S. official said Thursday. The men were not sophisticated mercenaries, relatives said, but poorly trained activists who wanted to send a message.

Some of the men's families
SEE CUBA ON A13

Tears in Chicago for civil rights leader



JOSHUA LOTT/REUTERS

Family members watch Thursday as the remains of the Rev. Jesse Jackson arrive at Rainbow Push headquarters in Chicago, where they will lie in repose. After losing the 1988 Democratic presidential nomination, the civil rights leader relocated to Washington, where he fought for statehood and faced pressure to run for mayor. **Story, B11**

DOJ probing if Epstein tranche hid Trump claims

BY PERRY STEIN

The Justice Department said Thursday that it is examining whether it wrongly withheld FBI files that contained allegations against President Donald Trump in its release of millions of pages from the investigatory files related to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

Three summaries of interviews the FBI conducted in 2019 with a woman who had accused Trump of sexually assaulting her are missing from the files, multiple news outlets have reported. The woman had accused Trump of sexually assaulting her decades earlier while she was a minor. No evidence has emerged publicly to corroborate that accusation.

The existence of the summaries — known as 302s in law

Missing files include FBI interviews into allegations of sex assault

enforcement parlance — was noted in an index that the Justice Department included in the massive cache of files released over the past three months in response to the Epstein Files Transparency Act. The index suggested that law enforcement agents interviewed the woman on four occasions, writing up a summary in each instance. Only one of the four summaries was included in the release.

The summaries were among the materials prosecutors gave to defense attorneys as part of the

discovery process leading up to the trial of Epstein's accomplice Ghislaine Maxwell, who was convicted in 2021 on sex-trafficking charges.

Independent journalist Roger Sollenberger first reported on the apparent missing files.

The woman who accused Trump also said Epstein assaulted her when she was a minor in the 1980s. In an account that was included in the files, the woman said that Epstein introduced her to Trump and that Trump assaulted her.

FBI agents frequently fill out 302s in cases that never lead to charges, and the accusations in them are generally considered unproven allegations.

Trump has repeatedly denied any wrongdoing in connection to Epstein.

“Several individuals and news outlets have recently flagged files related to documents produced to Ghislaine Maxwell in discovery of her criminal case that they claim appear to be missing,” the Justice Department said in a statement.

“As with all documents that have been flagged by the public, the Department is currently reviewing files within that category of the production. Should any document be found to have been improperly tagged in the review process and is responsive to the Act, the Department will of course publish it, consistent with the law.”

Epstein pleaded guilty in 2008 to two charges of soliciting prostitution, including one involving a minor. He was arrested on
SEE EPSTEIN ON A4

Trump eyes voting control

ACTIVISTS PITCH EMERGENCY ORDER

Draft proposing powers based on 2020 claims

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF

Pro-Trump activists who say they are in coordination with the White House are circulating a 17-page draft executive order that claims China interfered in the 2020 election as a basis to declare a national emergency that would unlock extraordinary presidential power over voting.

President Donald Trump has repeatedly previewed a plan to mandate voter ID and ban mail ballots in November's midterm elections, and the activists expect their draft will figure into Trump's promised executive order on the issue. The White House declined to elaborate on Trump's plans.

“Under the Constitution, it's the legislatures and states that really control how a state conducts its elections, and the president doesn't have any power to do that,” said Peter Ticktin, a Florida lawyer who is advocating for the draft executive order. Ticktin attended the New York Military Academy with Trump and was part of his legal team that filed an unsuccessful 2022 lawsuit accusing Democrats of conspiring to damage him with allegations that his 2016 campaign colluded with Russia.

“But here we have a situation where the president is aware that there are foreign interests that are interfering in our election processes,” Ticktin went on. “That causes a national emergency where the president has to be able to deal with it.”

The emergency would empower the president to ban mail ballots and voting machines as the vectors of foreign interference, Ticktin argued.

The idea of claiming emergency executive powers based on allegations of foreign interference
SEE ELECTION ON A6

Judge: IRS broke the law by giving data to DHS

BY JEFF STEIN

A federal judge has found that the Internal Revenue Service violated federal law “approximately 42,695 times” when it shared confidential taxpayer addresses with immigration enforcement officials last summer.

U.S. District Judge Colleen Kollar-Kotelly issued the ruling Thursday as part of ongoing litigation over a data-sharing arrangement between the IRS and the Department of Homeland Security.

Federal law requires that before the IRS hands over a taxpayer's address, a requesting agency must first provide the IRS with the name and address of the person it's looking for. The requirement exists to ensure that the government can access confidential tax records only for individuals it has already specifically identified.

The ruling finds that DHS did
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‘No chance’ U.S. will be in drawn-out Mideast war, Vance says



MATT ROURKE/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Vice President JD Vance returns from a trip to Wisconsin on Thursday. He told The Washington Post that he does not know what President Donald Trump will decide to do about Iran.

As Trump mulls Iran, VP is a ‘skeptical’ of overseas military intervention

BY NATALIE ALLISON

ABOARD AIR FORCE TWO — Vice President JD Vance said Thursday that while military strikes against Iran remain under consideration by President Donald Trump, there is “no chance” that such strikes would result in the United States becoming involved in a years-long, drawn-out war.

Speaking with The Washington Post on Thursday, Vance said he does not know what Trump will decide to do about Iran, describing possibilities that include military strikes “to ensure Iran isn't going to get a nuclear weapon,” or solving “the problem diplomatically.”

But if Trump proceeds with another round of strikes on Iran — which some U.S. officials have suggested could be more comprehensive than the bombing of nuclear sites in June — Vance said confidently that it would not

turn into the kind of conflict the vice president has harshly criticized.

“The idea that we're going to be in a Middle Eastern war for years with no end in sight — there is no chance that will happen,” he told The Post in an interview as he returned to Washington from an event in Wisconsin — effectively pushing back against predictions by some foreign policy experts that there would be no easy out if America got involved in a bigger conflict with Iran.

Vance noted that last year's operation in Iran and the January capture of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro were “very clearly defined.”

Vance, a 41-year-old Marine veteran who served in the Iraq War, once said from the Senate floor that he had been “lied to” about the reasons for the United States' involvement there. He said Thursday that he still sees himself as a “skeptical of foreign military interventions,” a description he believes continues to apply to Trump.

“I think we all prefer the diplomatic option,” Vance said. “But it really depends on what
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